NORTHGATE SOLUTIONS PVT. LTD.

Employee Handbook & HR Policy Manual

Version 4.2 | Effective 1 January 2026 | Human Resources Department

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This manual is confidential and intended solely for the internal use of Northgate Solutions Pvt. Ltd. employees. It is provided here as a sample/synthetic document for testing internal knowledge-base and RAG chatbot applications — all names, figures, and policies are fictional.

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1. Code of Conduct

All employees of Northgate Solutions are expected to act with integrity, professionalism, and respect toward colleagues, clients, and partners at all times. This section outlines the minimum standards of workplace behavior expected across all offices and remote work arrangements.

1.1 Professional Behavior

- Employees must treat all colleagues, clients, and vendors with courtesy and respect, regardless of role, seniority, or background.
- Discriminatory, abusive, or threatening language or behavior of any kind will not be tolerated.
- Conflicts of interest (e.g., outside employment, financial interests in vendors) must be disclosed to HR within 15 days of arising.

1.2 Confidentiality

Employees must not disclose confidential company information, client data, or trade secrets to any external party without written authorization from their reporting manager and the Legal department. This obligation continues for 24 months after separation from the company.

1.3 Disciplinary Action

Violations of the Code of Conduct are handled in three stages: (1) a verbal warning documented in the employee's file, (2) a written warning with a 30-day improvement plan, and (3) termination for repeated or severe violations, subject to review by HR and the employee's department head.

2. Working Hours & Attendance

Standard working hours at Northgate Solutions are 9:30 AM to 6:30 PM, Monday through Friday, with a one-hour lunch break. Core collaboration hours, during which all employees must be reachable, are 11:00 AM to 4:00 PM IST.

2.1 Attendance Tracking

- Employees must clock in/out via the HRMS portal (Northgate Connect) each working day.
- Employees arriving more than 30 minutes past their scheduled start time on 3 or more occasions in a month will receive an attendance advisory from HR.
- Field/client-site employees must mark attendance via the mobile app with geolocation enabled.

2.2 Overtime

Non-exempt employees who work beyond 45 hours in a given week are eligible for overtime compensation at 1.5x their standard hourly rate, subject to prior manager approval logged in Northgate Connect.

3. Leave Policy

Northgate Solutions provides the following categories of paid and unpaid leave to all confirmed full-time employees, prorated for employees who joined mid-year.

3.1 Leave Entitlements

- Casual Leave (CL): 12 days per calendar year, credited monthly.

- Sick Leave (SL): 10 days per calendar year; a medical certificate is required for absences exceeding 2 consecutive days.
- Earned/Privilege Leave (EL): 15 days per calendar year, accrued quarterly and carried forward up to a maximum of 45 days.
- Maternity Leave: 26 weeks of paid leave per the Maternity Benefit Act, extendable by 8 weeks unpaid upon request.
- Paternity Leave: 15 days of paid leave, to be availed within 3 months of the child's birth.
- Bereavement Leave: 5 days of paid leave for the death of an immediate family member.

3.2 Leave Application Process

All leave (except sick leave for sudden illness) must be applied for at least 3 working days in advance through Northgate Connect and approved by the employee's direct manager. Sick leave taken without prior notice must be regularized within 2 working days of returning to work.

3.3 Unpaid Leave

Employees who have exhausted their paid leave balance may request unpaid leave of up to 30 days per year, subject to approval by their department head and HR Business Partner.

4. Work From Home & Hybrid Policy

Northgate Solutions follows a hybrid work model for eligible roles, allowing a blend of in-office and remote work to support flexibility while maintaining team collaboration.

4.1 Eligibility & Schedule

- Employees in eligible roles may work remotely up to 2 days per week, subject to manager approval.
- Employees must be present in-office on designated “anchor days” as communicated by their department.
- Fully remote arrangements require sign-off from the department head and HR, reviewed every 6 months.

4.2 Remote Work Expectations

Remote employees are expected to maintain the same working hours, availability, and responsiveness as in-office staff, and must have a stable internet connection and a dedicated, professional workspace for video calls.

5. Compensation & Benefits

5.1 Salary Structure & Payment

Salaries are credited to employees' registered bank accounts by the last working day of each month. Salary revisions are reviewed annually as part of the performance appraisal cycle, effective April 1 each year.

5.2 Benefits

- Group health insurance covering the employee, spouse, and up to 2 dependent children, with an annual sum insured of ■5,00,000.
- Provident Fund (PF) contribution as per statutory requirements, matched by the company.
- Annual wellness allowance of ■10,000 for gym memberships, mental health support, or preventive health checkups.

- Employee Stock Option Plan (ESOP) eligibility for employees at Senior Associate level and above, per the ESOP policy document.

6. Expense Reimbursement Policy

Employees incurring business-related expenses (client travel, team offsites, approved training, etc.) may claim reimbursement through Northgate Connect within 30 days of the expense being incurred.

6.1 Claimable Expenses

- Domestic travel: economy-class airfare or AC 2-tier train fare, plus local conveyance with receipts.
- Accommodation: up to ■6,000 per night for metro cities, ■4,000 per night for non-metro cities.
- Client meals: up to ■1,500 per person per meal, itemized receipts required for claims over ■1,000.
- Internet/phone reimbursement for remote employees: up to ■1,500 per month with a valid bill.

6.2 Approval Workflow

All claims above ■5,000 require approval from both the reporting manager and the Finance controller before disbursement, which is processed in the following payroll cycle.

7. Performance Review Process

Northgate Solutions conducts performance reviews twice a year: a mid-year check-in (informal, development-focused) and an annual review (formal, tied to compensation and promotion decisions).

7.1 Review Cycle

- Self-assessment submitted by the employee, followed by manager evaluation and calibration across teams.
- Ratings are given on a 5-point scale: Needs Improvement, Meets Some Expectations, Meets Expectations, Exceeds Expectations, Outstanding.
- Promotion nominations are reviewed by a cross-functional panel during the annual cycle only.

8. Anti-Harassment & Grievance Policy

Northgate Solutions maintains a zero-tolerance policy toward workplace harassment, including sexual harassment, in compliance with the POSH Act, 2013.

8.1 Reporting Mechanism

- Complaints may be filed with the Internal Complaints Committee (ICC) via email, the HR portal, or in person.
- All complaints are acknowledged within 2 working days and investigated within 90 days as mandated by law.
- Retaliation against any employee who files a complaint in good faith is strictly prohibited and is itself a disciplinary offense.

9. IT & Data Security Policy

9.1 Acceptable Use

- Company laptops and accounts must not be used to access unauthorized or non-business-related services that pose a security risk.
- Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is mandatory for all company systems, including email and internal tools.
- Client data must never be stored on personal devices or personal cloud storage accounts.

9.2 Incident Reporting

Any suspected data breach, phishing attempt, or lost/stolen device must be reported to the IT Security team within 2 hours of discovery via the emergency IT hotline.

10. Separation & Exit Policy

10.1 Notice Period

The standard notice period is 60 days for employees at Associate level and above, and 30 days for Trainee/Intern roles. The company reserves the right to relieve an employee earlier with pay in lieu of the remaining notice period.

10.2 Exit Process

- Exit interview conducted by HR within the final week of the notice period.
- Full and final settlement processed within 45 days of the last working day, including pending reimbursements and leave encashment.
- Return of all company assets (laptop, ID card, access cards) is mandatory before the final settlement is released.